

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2010-12-28

To the Conference of the Continental Boards of Cou

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28 December 2010

To the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors

Dearly loved Friends,

^{16.1} Fifteen years have elapsed since, on an occasion such as

this, we gave to the body of Counsellors assembled in the Holy

Land the first intimation of the course the Bahá'í community

would have to take, if it was to accelerate the dual process of its

expansion and consolidation—a course which its accumulated

¹⁷ experience had prepared it to steer with confidence. No need to remark on the distance traversed in a short decade and a

half. The record of accomplishments speaks for itself. Today we

¹⁸ invite you to begin deliberations on the next stage of the great enterprise on which the Bahá'í world is embarked, a stage that

will stretch from Rid .ván 2011 to Rid .ván 2016, constituting

¹⁹ the first of two consecutive Five Year Plans that will culminate at the centenary of the inauguration of the Faith's Formative

²⁰ Age. Over the coming days you are asked to formulate a clear conception of how the Counsellors and their auxiliaries

will assist the community in building on its extraordinary

21 achievements—extending to other spheres of operation the mode of learning which
has so undeniably come to characterize

its teaching endeavors, gaining the capacity needed to employ

with a high degree of coherence the instruments and methods

which it has so painstakingly developed, and increasing well

22 beyond all previous numbers the ranks of those who, alive to the vision of the Faith,
are laboring so assiduously in pursuit of

23 its God-given mission.

16.2 In our Rid .ván message this year, we described the dynamics

17 of the process of learning that, through four successive global Plans, has steadily
gathered momentum, enhancing the capacity

of the friends to engage in grassroots action. The vista from this

vantage point is stupendous indeed. With more than 350,000

18 souls worldwide who have completed the first institute course,

19 96

20 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONcapacity to shape a pattern of life distinguished for its
devotion-

al character has risen perceptibly. In diverse settings, on every

21 continent, groups of believers are uniting with others in prayer,

turning their hearts in supplication to their Maker, and calling

to their aid those spiritual forces upon which the efficacy of

22 their individual and collective efforts depends. A near doubling in the reserve of
Bahá'í children's class teachers in a five-year

period, bringing the total to some 130,000, has made it possible

23 for the community to respond wholeheartedly to the spiritual aspirations of the
young. A sixfold increase in capacity over the

same period to assist junior youth in navigating through such

a crucial stage of their lives provides an indication of the level

of commitment to that age group. What is more, everywhere, a

24 notable number of friends find themselves ready to enter into conversation with
people of varied backgrounds and interests

and to undertake with them an exploration of reality that gives

²⁵ rise to a shared understanding of the exigencies of this period in human history and the means for addressing them. And

fueling the systematic multiplication of core activities across the

globe, with no fewer than half a million known participants at

a given time, are the efforts of close to 70,000 friends capable

²⁶ of serving as tutors of study circles.

^{16.3} As made clear in our Ridván message, in the system thus

created to develop its human resources, the community of the

Greatest Name possesses an instrument of limitless potenti-

alities. Under a wide diversity of conditions, in virtually any

cluster, it is possible for an expanding nucleus of individuals

¹⁷ to generate a movement towards the goal of a new World Order. A decade ago, when we introduced the concept of a

cluster—a geographic construct intended to facilitate thinking

¹⁸ about the growth of the Faith—we provided an outline of four broad stages along the path of its development. As the

Bahá'í community set about implementing the provisions of the

Plan, this outline proved immensely useful in giving shape and

definition to what is essentially an ongoing process. The abun-

¹⁹ dant experience which has since accrued enables the believers now to conceive of the movement of a population, propelled

by mounting spiritual forces, in terms of a rich and dynamic

²⁰ continuum. A brief review of the process that unfolds in a cluster, though well familiar to you all, will serve to underscore

²¹ its fundamentally organic nature.

²² 97

^{16.4} Invariably, opportunities afforded by the personal circum-

stances of the believers initially involved—or perhaps a single

homefront pioneer—to enter into meaningful and distinctive

conversation with local residents dictate how the process of

growth begins in a cluster. A study circle made up of a few

¹⁷ friends or colleagues, a class offered for several neighborhood children, a group formed for junior youth during after-school hours, a devotional gathering hosted for family and friends—

any one of these can serve as a stimulus to growth. What

happens next follows no predetermined course. Conditions may

justify that one core activity be given precedence, multiplying at

¹⁸ a rate faster than the others. It is equally possible that all four would advance at a comparable pace. Visiting teams may be

¹⁹ called upon to provide impetus to the fledgling set of activities.

²⁰ But irrespective of the specifics, the outcome must be the same. Within every cluster, the level of cohesion achieved among the

core activities must be such that, in their totality, a nascent

program for the sustained expansion and consolidation of the

Faith can be perceived. That is to say, in whatever combination

²¹ and however small in number, devotional gatherings, children's classes and junior youth groups are being maintained by those

progressing through the sequence of institute courses and com-

²² mitted to the vision of individual and collective transformation they foster. This initial flow of human resources into the field

of systematic action marks the first of several milestones in a

²³ process of sustainable growth.

^{16.5} All of the institutions and agencies promoting the aim of

the current series of global Plans need to exercise the measure

of agility that the birth of such a dynamic process demands—

but none more so than the Auxiliary Board members. To help

the friends visualize this first important milestone, and the

¹⁷ multiplicity of ways in which it can be reached, is central to the functioning of every Auxiliary Board member and an increasing

number of his or her assistants. In this, as in all their work, they

18 must display breadth of vision and clarity of thought, flexibility and resourcefulness.
They should stand shoulder to shoulder

**with the friends, supporting them through their struggles and
partaking in their joys. Some of these friends will quickly move
to the forefront of activity, while others will step forward more**

19 tentatively; yet all require support and encouragement, offered not in the abstract but
on the basis of that intimate knowledge

20 98

21 **FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION**which is only acquired by working side by side in the
field of

**service. Faith in the capacity of every individual who shows a
desire to serve will prove essential to the efforts of those who
are to elicit from the believers wholehearted participation in
the Plan. Unqualified love free of paternalism will be indis-**

22 pensable if they are to help turn hesitation into courage born of trust in God and
transform a yearning for excitement into

a commitment to long-term action. Calm determination will

23 be vital as they strive to demonstrate how stumbling blocks can be made stepping
stones for progress. And a readiness to

listen, with heightened spiritual perception, will be invaluable in

identifying obstacles that may prevent some of the friends from

24 appreciating the imperative of unified action.

Increasing intensity

16.6 It is important to note that, as a program of growth is being

17 brought into existence, an emergent community spirit begins to exert its influence on
the course of events. Whether activities

are scattered across the cluster or concentrated in one village

or neighborhood, a sense of common purpose characterizes the

18 endeavors of the friends. Whatever level of organization served to channel the early
manifestations of this spirit, the systematic,

coordinated multiplication of core activities necessitates that

19 higher levels soon be attained. Through various measures, greater structure is lent to activity, and initiative, shaped largely

20 by individual volition before, is now given collective expression.

A complement of coordinators appointed by the institute moves

into place—those for study circles, for junior youth groups, and

21 for children's classes. Any order of appointment is potentially valid. Nothing less than an acute awareness of circumstances on

the ground should make this determination, for what is at stake

22 is not compliance with a set of procedures but the unfoldment of an educational process that has begun to show its potential

23 to bring about the spiritual empowerment of large numbers.

16.7 Parallel to the establishment of mechanisms to support the

17 institute process, other administrative structures are gradually taking shape. Out of the occasional meetings of a few believers

emerge the regular deliberations of an expanding core group of

friends concerned with channeling into the field of service an

18 increasing store of energy. As the process of growth continues to gather momentum, such an arrangement ultimately fails

to satisfy the demands of planning and decision making, and

19 99

meetings institutionalized. In the joint interactions of the

Committee, the institute and the Auxiliary Board members, a

fully fledged scheme for the coordination of activities becomes

operational—with all the inherent capacity needed to facilitate

20 the efficient flow of guidance, funds, and information. By now, the process of growth in the cluster will conform to the rhythm

established by pronounced cycles of expansion and consolida-

21 tion, which, punctuated every three months by a meeting for reflection and planning, are unfolding without interruption.

16.8 Here again, it is for the Auxiliary Board members and

other relevant institutions and agencies, such as the Regional

Council and institute board, to ensure that administrative

structures being forged in the cluster take on the requisite

characteristics. Specifically, the sequence of courses that we

¹⁷ have recommended for use by institutes everywhere, which is facilitating so effectively the process of transformation

under way, is designed to create an environment conducive

¹⁸ at once to universal participation and to mutual support and assistance. The nature of relationships among individuals in

this environment, all of whom consider themselves as treading

a common path of service, was explained briefly in our Rid .ván

¹⁹ message. We also indicated there that such an environment is not without its effects on the administrative affairs of the Faith. As an increasing number of believers participate in the teaching

and administrative work, undertaken with a humble attitude of

²⁰ learning, they should come to view every task, every interaction, as an occasion to join hands in the pursuit of progress and to

accompany one another in their efforts to serve the Cause. In

this way will the impulse to over instruct be quieted. In this way

will the tendency to reduce a complex process of transforma-

²¹ tion into simplistic steps, susceptible to instruction by manual, be averted. Discrete actions are placed in context, and even

the smallest of steps is endowed with meaning. The operation

of spiritual forces in the arena of service becomes increasingly

apparent, and bonds of friendship, so vital to a healthy pattern

²² of growth, are continuously reinforced.

^{16.9} Within this landscape of unfolding processes, emerging

structures, and enduring fellowship, that moment which has

come to be known as the “launching” of an intensive program

of growth represents conscious recognition that all the elements

necessary to accelerate the expansion and consolidation of

¹⁷ 100

18 **FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION**the Faith are not only in place but also functioning with
an

**adequate degree of effectiveness. It signals the maturation of
an ever-expanding, self-sustaining system for the spiritual edifi-
cation of a population: a steady stream of friends is proceeding
through the courses of the training institute and engaging in the**

19 corresponding activities, which serves, in turn, to increase the number of fresh
recruits into the Faith, a significant percentage

of whom invariably enters the institute process, guaranteeing

20 the expansion of the system. This constitutes another milestone that the friends
laboring in every cluster must, in time, reach.

16.10 In reiterating here much of what we have stated on previous

**occasions, we hope to have impressed upon you how readily
the movement of a population, inspired by the purpose and
principles of the Cause, can be nurtured, when not made the
object of extraneous complications. We have no illusion that**

17 the path traced out so summarily above is devoid of difficulty. Progress is achieved
through the dialectic of crisis and victory,

and setbacks are inevitable. A drop in participation, a disrup-

18 tion in the cycles of activity, a momentary breach in the bonds of unity—these are
among the myriad challenges that may have

**to be met. Not infrequently the rise in human resources, or the
ability to mobilize them, will fall short of the demands of rapid
expansion. Yet the imposition of formulas on the process will**

19 not result in a pattern of growth characterized by the desired equilibrium. Temporary
imbalances in the progress of different

activities are intrinsic to the process, and they can be adjusted

20 over time, if dealt with patiently. Scaling back one activity that is flourishing, on the
basis of theoretical conceptions of how

**balanced growth can be achieved, often proves counterproduc-
tive. While the friends in a cluster might well benefit from the**

experience of those who have already established the necessary

21 pattern of action, it is only through continued action, reflection and consultation on
their part that they will learn to read their

own reality, see their own possibilities, make use of their own

resources, and respond to the exigencies of large-scale expan-

22 sion and consolidation to come.

16.11 Today, there are some 1,600 clusters worldwide where

17 the friends have succeeded in creating the pattern of action associated with an
intensive program of growth. Though

significant, this accomplishment can by no means be considered

the culmination of the process that has gathered momentum

in each cluster. New frontiers of learning are now open to the

18 101

of vibrant communities, growing in size and reflecting in greater

and greater degrees Bahá'u'lláh's vision for humanity. Such

clusters will also need to serve as reservoirs of potential pio-

neers that can be dispatched, largely across the home front, to

19 cluster after cluster, shedding in some the first rays of the light of His Revelation and
strengthening in others the presence of

the Faith, enabling all to progress quickly to the first milestone

20 along the path of development, or beyond. With this in mind, we will call upon the
community of the Most Great Name at

Rid.ván 2011 to raise over the next five years the total number

21 of clusters in which a program of growth is under way, at whatever level of intensity,
to 5,000, approximately one third

22 of all clusters in the world at present.

Advancing the frontiers of learning

16.12 What we have described in the preceding paragraphs and

in so many messages over the last decade and a half can best be

viewed as the latest in a series of approaches to the growth of

the Bahá'í community, each suited to specific historical circum-

stances. This divinely propelled process of growth was set in

¹⁷ motion by the fervor generated in the Cradle of the Faith more than one hundred and sixty years ago, as thousands responded

to the summons of a New Day, and received impetus through

¹⁸ the exertions made by early believers to carry the message of Bahá'u'lláh to neighboring countries in the East and scattered

pockets in the West. It acquired greater structure through the

Tablets of the Divine Plan revealed by 'Abdu'l-Bahá and gained

momentum as the friends spread out systematically across

¹⁹ the globe under the direction of the Guardian to establish small centers of Bahá'í activity and erect the first pillars of the

Administrative Order. It gathered force in the rural areas of

²⁰ the world as masses of humanity were moved to embrace the Faith, but slowed considerably as the friends strove to discover

strategies for sustaining large-scale expansion and consolida-

tion. And, for fifteen years now, it has been steadily accelerating

since we raised the call at the outset of the Four Year Plan for

²¹ the Bahá'í world to systematize the teaching work on the basis of the experience it had gained through decades of difficult

²² but invaluable learning. That the current approach to growth,

effective as it is, must evolve still further in complexity and

sophistication once it has taken root in a cluster, demonstrating

²³ 102

²⁴ FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONNever more notably the "society-building power" inherent in the

²⁵ Faith, few would fail to recognize.

^{16.13} Referring to the development of the global Bahá'í com-

munity, how often did the beloved Guardian encourage the

friends to remain resolute in their purpose and persevere in

17 their endeavors. "Conscious of their high calling, confident in the society-building power which their Faith possesses," he

noted with satisfaction, "they press forward, undeterred and

18 undismayed, in their efforts to fashion and perfect the necessary instruments wherein the embryonic World Order of Bahá'u'lláh

can mature and develop." "It is this building process, slow

and unobtrusive," he reminded them, that "constitutes the

one hope" of a disillusioned humanity. That this process will

19 continue to gain in scope and influence and the Administrative Order demonstrate in time "its capacity to be regarded not only

as the nucleus but the very pattern of the New World Order"

20 is clear from his writings. "In a world the structure of whose political and social institutions is impaired, whose vision is

befogged, whose conscience is bewildered, whose religious

systems have become anaemic and lost their virtue," he asserted

so emphatically, "this healing Agency, this leavening Power, this

21 cementing Force, intensely alive and all-pervasive," is "taking shape," is "crystallizing into institutions," and is "mobilizing

its forces."

16.14 What should be apparent is that, if the Administrative

17 Order is to serve as a pattern for future society, then the community within which it is developing must not only acquire

capacity to address increasingly complex material and spiritual

requirements but also become larger and larger in size. How

18 could it be otherwise. A small community, whose members are united by their shared beliefs, characterized by their high ideals,

19 proficient in managing their affairs and tending to their needs,

20 and perhaps engaged in several humanitarian projects—a community such as this, prospering but at a comfortable distance

from the reality experienced by the masses of humanity, can

never hope to serve as a pattern for restructuring the whole of

society. That the worldwide Bahá'í community has managed

21 to avert the dangers of complacency is a source of abiding joy to us. Indeed, the community has well in hand its expansion

and consolidation. Yet, to administer the affairs of teeming

numbers in villages and cities around the globe—to raise aloft

22 103

23 a distant goal.

16,15 Therein, then, lies the challenge that must be faced by those

in the forefront of the learning process which will continue to

advance over the course of the next Plan. Wherever an intensive

17 program of growth is established, let the friends spare no effort to increase the level of participation. Let them strain every

nerve to ensure that the system which they have so laboriously

18 erected does not close in on itself but progressively expands to embrace more and more people. Let them not lose sight of

the remarkable receptivity they found—nay, the sense of eager

expectation that awaited them—as they gained confidence in

their ability to interact with people of all walks of life and

19 converse with them about the Person of Bahá'u'lláh and His Revelation. Let them hold fast to the conviction that a direct

presentation of the Faith, when carried out at a sufficient level

20 of depth and reinforced by a sound approach to consolidation, can bring enduring results. And let them not forget the lessons

of the past which left no doubt that a relatively small band

21 of active supporters of the Cause, no matter how resourceful,

no matter how consecrated, cannot attend to the needs of

22 communities comprising hundreds, much less thousands, of men, women and children. The implications are clear enough.

If, in a cluster, those shouldering responsibility for expansion

23 and consolidation number in the tens, with a few hundred participating in the activities of community life, both figures

should rise significantly so that by the end of the Plan, one or

two hundred are facilitating the participation of one or two

24 thousand.

16.16 It is heartening to see that, already in some 300 of the

17 1,600 clusters worldwide with intensive programs of growth in operation, the believers have entered the new arena of learning

now open to them, and, in more than a few, they are extending

its frontiers. Clearly, in all such clusters, strengthening the edu-

18 cational processes set in motion by the training institute, each with its own requisites—regularly held classes for the youngest

members of society, close-knit groups for junior youth, and

circles of study for youth and adults—is of paramount impor -

tance. Much of what this work entails was discussed in the

Rid.ván message. Without exception, having witnessed the trans-

formative effects of the institute process firsthand, the friends

in such clusters are striving to gain a fuller appreciation of the

19 104

20 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONdynamics that underlie it—the spirit of fellowship it creates, the

participatory approach it adopts, the depth of understanding

it fosters, the acts of service it recommends, and, above all, its

reliance on the Word of God. Every effort is being exerted to

ensure that the process reflects the complementarity of “being”

21 and “doing” the institute courses make explicit; the centrality they accord to knowledge and its application; the emphasis

they place on avoiding false dichotomies; the stress they lay on

22 memorization of the Creative Word; and the care they exercise in raising consciousness, without awakening the insistent self.

Enhancing administrative capacity

16.17 Though the central elements of the process of growth

17 remain unchanged in the clusters in the vanguard of learning,

sheer numbers require organizational schemes to take on a higher degree of complexity. Different innovations have already been introduced, on the basis of both geographic considerations

and numerical growth. The division of the cluster into

18 smaller units, the decentralization of the reflection meeting,

the assignment of assistants to institute coordinators, the

19 deployment in teams of experienced friends to support others in the field—these are some of the arrangements that have

been made thus far. We have every confidence that, with your

able assistance, the International Teaching Centre will follow

these developments over the course of the next Plan, helping to

20 consolidate the lessons learned into well-proven methods and instruments. To this end, you and your auxiliaries will need

to cultivate an atmosphere that encourages the friends to be

21 methodical but not rigid, creative but not haphazard, decisive but not hasty, careful but not controlling, recognizing that,

22 in the final analysis, it is not technique but unity of thought,

consistent action, and dedication to learning which will bring

23 about progress.

16,18 Whatever the nature of the arrangements made at the

17 cluster level for coordinating large-scale activity, continued progress will depend on the development of Local Spiritual

Assemblies and on the increased capacity of Regional Bahá'í

Councils and ultimately National Spiritual Assemblies. In the

Rid.ván message we expressed pleasure at noting the growing

strength of National Assemblies, and we look to the coming

five years with optimism, certain that we will see significant

18 leaps forward in this respect. Moreover, we have no doubt that,

19 105

Regional Councils enhance their institutional capacity. There

are currently 170 such administrative bodies in 45 countries

worldwide, and their number is sure to climb during the next

Plan. It will be imperative that all Regional Councils pay close

²⁰ attention to the operation of the training institute and the functioning of Area Teaching Committees. With this in mind, they

will find it necessary to create and refine mechanisms that serve

²¹ to further the pattern of growth unfolding at the cluster level and the learning process associated with it. These will include a

well-functioning regional office that provides the secretary with

basic organizational support; a sound system of accounting that

accommodates diverse channels for the flow of funds to and

²² from clusters; an efficient means of communication that takes into consideration the reality of life in villages and neighbor -

²³ hoods; and, where warranted, physical structures that facilitate intensified and focused activity. What is important to acknowledge in this respect is that only if the Councils themselves are

engaged in a process of learning will such mechanisms prove

to be effective. Otherwise, while ostensibly created to support

learning in action by an increasing number of participants in

²⁴ neighborhoods and villages, systems being developed may well work against it in subtle ways, stifling, unintentionally, rising

²⁵ aspirations at the grass roots.

^{16.19} While collaboration with National Spiritual Assemblies

¹⁷ and Regional Councils will be one of your primary concerns, your auxiliaries will need to direct more and more of their

energies towards fostering institutional capacity at the local

level, where the demands of community building assert them-

selves so unmistakably. To help you envision what lies ahead

¹⁸ of Auxiliary Board members and their assistants everywhere,

particularly in clusters experiencing large-scale expansion and

¹⁹ consolidation, we ask you to reflect, first, on the development of Local Spiritual Assemblies in the many rural areas of the

world, in which the vast majority of such clusters today are to
20 be found.

16.20 As you are aware, often in a rural cluster made up of
villages and perhaps one or two towns, while the pattern of
action associated with an intensive program of growth is being
established, the efforts of the friends are confined to a few
localities. Once in place, however, the pattern can be extended
quickly to village after village, as explained in our Rid .ván

17 106

18 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONmessage this year. Early on in each locality, the Local
Spiritual

Assembly comes into existence, and its steady development
follows a trajectory parallel with, and intimately tied to, the
fledgling process of growth unfolding in the village. And not
unlike the evolution of other facets of this process, the devel-

19 opment of the Local Assembly can best be understood in terms of capacity building.

16.21 What needs to occur in the first instance is relatively
straightforward: Individual awareness of the process of growth
gathering momentum in the village, born of each member's
personal involvement in the core activities, must coalesce into

a collective consciousness that recognizes both the nature of the

17 transformation under way and the obligation of the Assembly to foster it. Without
doubt, some attention will have to be

18 given to certain basic administrative functions—for example,

19 meeting with a degree of regularity, conducting the Nineteen Day Feast and planning
Holy Day observances, establishing

a local fund, and holding annual elections in accordance with

Bahá'í principle. However, it should not prove difficult for

the Local Assembly to begin, concomitant with such efforts

20 and with encouragement from an assistant to an Auxiliary Board member, to consult as a body on one or two specific

21 issues with immediate relevance to the life of the community:

22 how the devotional character of the village is being enhanced through the efforts of individuals who have completed the first

institute course; how the spiritual education of the children

is being addressed by teachers raised up by the institute; how

the potential of junior youth is being realized by the program

23 for their spiritual empowerment; how the spiritual and social fabric of the community is being strengthened as the friends

visit one another in their homes. As the Assembly consults

on such tangible matters and learns to nurture the process

of growth lovingly and patiently, its relationship with the

24 Area Teaching Committee and the training institute gradually becomes cemented in a common purpose. But, of still greater

importance, it will begin to lay the foundations on which can

25 be built that uniquely affectionate and genuinely supportive relationship, described by the beloved Guardian in many of his

messages, which Local Spiritual Assemblies should establish

26 with the individual believer.

16,22 Clearly, learning to consult on specific issues related to

the global Plan, no matter how crucial, represents but one

17 107

Spiritual Assembly must engage. Its continued development

implies adherence to the injunction laid down by ‘Abdu’l-Bahá

that “discussions must all be confined to spiritual matters that

18 pertain to the training of souls, the instruction of children,

19 the relief of the poor, the help of the feeble throughout all classes in the world, kindness to all peoples, the diffusion of

the fragrances of God and the exaltation of His Holy Word.”

20 Its steady advancement requires an unbending commitment to promote the best interests of the community and a vigilance

in guarding the process of growth against the forces of moral

decay that threaten to arrest it. Its ongoing progress calls for a

sense of responsibility that extends beyond the circle of friends

21 and families engaged in the core activities to encompass the entire population of the village. And sustaining its gradual

maturation is unshakable faith in 'Abdu'l-Bahá's assurance that

22 He will enfold every Spiritual Assembly within the embrace of His care and protection.

16,23 Associated with this rise in collective consciousness is the

Assembly's growing ability to properly assess and utilize re-

sources, financial and otherwise, both in support of community

activities and in discharging its administrative functions, which

may in time include the judicious appointment of committees

17 and the maintenance of modest physical facilities for its operations. No less vital is its ability to nurture an environment

conducive to the participation of large numbers in unified

18 action and to ensure that their energies and talents contribute towards progress. In all these respects, the spiritual well-being

19 of the community remains uppermost in the Assembly's mind.

And when inevitable problems arise, whether in relation to

some activity or among individuals, they will be addressed by

20 a Local Spiritual Assembly which has so completely gained the confidence of the members of the community that all naturally

turn to it for assistance. This implies that the Assembly has

21 learned through experience how to help the believers put aside the divisive ways of a partisan mindset, how to find the seeds

of unity in even the most perplexing and thorny situations and

how to nurture them slowly and lovingly, upholding at all times

22 the standard of justice.

16.24 As the community grows in size and in capacity to maintain
17 vitality, the friends will, we have indicated in the past, be drawn further into the life
of society and be challenged to take

18 108

19 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION advantage of the approaches they have developed to
respond to

a widening range of issues that face their village. The question

of coherence, so essential to the growth achieved thus far, and

20 so fundamental to the Plan's evolving framework for action,

now assumes new dimensions. Much will fall on the Local

21 Assembly, not as an executor of projects but as the voice of moral authority, to make
certain that, as the friends strive to

apply the teachings of the Faith to improve conditions through

22 a process of action, reflection and consultation, the integrity of their endeavors is not
compromised.

16.25 Our Rid .ván message described a few of the characteristics of

17 social action at the grass roots, and the conditions it must meet.

Efforts in a village will generally begin on a small scale, perhaps

with the emergence of groups of friends, each concerned with

a specific social or economic need it has identified and each

18 pursuing a simple set of appropriate actions. Consultation at the Nineteen Day Feast
creates a space for the growing

social consciousness of the community to find constructive

19 expression. Whatever the nature of activities undertaken, the Local Assembly must
be attentive to potential pitfalls and help

the friends, if necessary, to steer past them—the allurements

of overly ambitious projects that would consume energies and

ultimately prove untenable, the temptation of financial grants

20 that would necessitate a departure from Bahá'í principle, the promises of
technologies deceptively packaged that would strip

the village of its cultural heritage and lead to fragmentation

²¹ and dissonance. Eventually the strength of the institute process in the village, and the enhanced capabilities it has fostered in

individuals, may enable the friends to take advantage of methods and programs of proven effectiveness, which have been developed by one or another Bahá'í-inspired organization and

²² which have been introduced into the cluster at the suggestion of, and with support from, our Office of Social and Economic

Development. Moreover, the Assembly must learn to interact with social and political structures in the locality, gradually raising consciousness of the presence of the Faith and the

²³ influence it is exerting on the progress of the village.

^{16.26} What is outlined in the foregoing paragraphs represents **only a few of the attributes which Local Spiritual Assemblies in the many villages of the world will gradually develop in serving the needs of communities that embrace larger and larger numbers. As they increasingly manifest their latent capacities and**

¹⁷ 109

of each village as "the trusted ones of the Merciful among men."

Thus will these Assemblies become "shining lamps and heavenly gardens, from which the fragrances of holiness are diffused over all regions, and the lights of knowledge are shed abroad

¹⁸ over all created things. From them the spirit of life streameth in every direction."

^{16.27} Such a lofty vision applies equally, of course, to all Local **Spiritual Assemblies throughout the world. Even in a major metropolitan area, the nature of an Assembly's development is fundamentally the same as the one delineated above. Differences lie principally in size and diversity of the population. The first**

¹⁷ necessitates the division of the Assembly's area of jurisdiction into neighborhoods according to the exigencies of growth and

the gradual introduction of mechanisms for administering the

18 affairs of the Faith in each. The second requires the Assembly to become familiar with the myriad social spaces, beyond

geographic ones, in which segments of the population come

together and to offer them, to the extent possible, the wisdom

enshrined in the teachings. Further, the institutional structures

19 in an urban area—social, political, and cultural—with which the Assembly must learn to engage are much wider in range

20 and larger in number.

Service on Bahá'í institutions

16.28 In setting out for you in these pages developments we are

17 eager to see in the administrative work of the Faith during the next Five Year Plan, we are reminded of the repeated warnings

raised by the Guardian in this regard. “Let us take heed lest

in our great concern for the perfection of the administrative

18 machinery of the Cause,” he stated, “we lose sight of the Divine Purpose for which it has been created.” The Bahá'í administra-

tive machinery, he reiterated again and again, “is to be regarded

19 as a means, and not an end in itself.” It is intended, he made clear, “to serve a twofold purpose.” On the one hand, “it should

aim at a steady and gradual expansion” of the Cause “along

lines that are at once broad, sound and universal.” On the

other, “it should ensure the internal consolidation of the work

20 already achieved.” And he went on to explain: “It should both provide the impulse whereby the dynamic forces latent in the

Faith can unfold, crystallize, and shape the lives and conduct

of men, and serve as a medium for the interchange of thought

21 110

22 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION and the coordination of activities among the divers elements

that constitute the Bahá'í community.”

16.29 It is our earnest hope that, in your efforts over the next Plan

to promote the sound and harmonious development of Bahá'í

administration at all levels, from the local to the national, you

¹⁷ will do your utmost to help the friends carry out their functions in the context of the organic process of growth gathering

momentum across the globe. The realization of this hope will

¹⁸ hinge, to a large extent, on the degree to which those who have been called upon to render such service—whether elected to a

Spiritual Assembly or named to one of its agencies, whether

designated an institute coordinator or appointed one of your

deputies—recognize the great privilege that is theirs and under -

¹⁹ stand the boundaries which this privilege establishes for them.

^{16.30} Service on the institutions and agencies of the Faith is

¹⁷ indeed a tremendous privilege, but not one that is sought by the individual; it is a duty and responsibility to which he or she

¹⁸ may be called at any given time. It is understandable, of course,

that all those involved in Bahá'í administration would rightly

¹⁹ feel they have been invested with a singular honor in forming part, in whatever way, of a structure designed to be a channel

through which the spirit of the Cause flows. Yet they should

²⁰ not imagine that such service entitles them to operate on the periphery of the learning process that is everywhere gaining

strength, exempt from its inherent requirements. Nor should

it be supposed that membership on administrative bodies

provides an opportunity to promote one's own understanding

²¹ of what is recorded in the Sacred Text and how the teachings should be applied, steering the community in whatever

direction personal preferences dictate. Referring to members

²² of Spiritual Assemblies, the Guardian wrote that they “must disregard utterly their own likes and dislikes, their personal

interests and inclinations, and concentrate their minds upon

those measures that will conduce to the welfare and happiness

of the Bahá'í Community and promote the common weal."

²³ Bahá'í institutions do exercise authority to guide the friends, and exert moral, spiritual and intellectual influence on the

lives of individuals and communities. However, such functions

are to be performed with the realization that an ethos of

loving service pervades Bahá'í institutional identity. Qualifying

²⁴ authority and influence in this manner implies sacrifice on the part of those entrusted to administer the affairs of the Faith.

²⁵ 111

into the forge, its ferrous qualities of blackness, coldness and

solidity, which symbolize the attributes of the human world, are

concealed and disappear, while the fire's distinctive qualities of

redness, heat and fluidity, which symbolize the virtues of the

²⁶ Kingdom, become visibly apparent in it." As He averred, "ye must in this matter—that is, the serving of humankind—lay

down your very lives, and as ye yield yourselves, rejoice."

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^{16.31} Dearly loved friends: As you well know, we take great

¹⁷ pleasure in witnessing how ably you and your auxiliaries, serving in the forefront of the teaching field, are carrying out

your duties to nurture in every heart and soul the fire of the

love of God, to promote learning, and to assist all in their

¹⁸ endeavors to develop an upright and praiseworthy character. When the North American Bahá'í community embarked on

its first Seven Year Plan, in pursuit of the responsibilities with

¹⁹ which it had been charged in the Tablets of the Divine Plan, the Guardian addressed to the friends in that land a letter of

considerable length and great potency, dated 25 December

²⁰ 1938, subsequently published under the title The Advent of

²¹ Divine Justice. Elaborating on the nature of the tasks at hand,

²² the letter made reference to what the Guardian described as spiritual prerequisites for the success of all Bahá'í undertakings.

Of these, three, he indicated, “stand out as preeminent and

²³ vital”: rectitude of conduct, a chaste and holy life, and freedom from prejudice. Given the conditions of the world today, you

would do well to reflect on the implications of his observations

for the global effort of the Bahá’í community to infuse cluster

²⁴ after cluster with the spirit of Bahá’u’lláh’s Revelation.

^{16,32} Referring to rectitude of conduct, Shoghi Effendi spoke

¹⁷ of the “justice, equity, truthfulness, honesty, fair-mindedness, reliability, and trustworthiness” that must “distinguish every

phase of the life of the Bahá’í community.” Though applicable

to all its members, this requisite was directed principally, he

¹⁸ underscored, to its “elected representatives, whether local, regional, or national,” whose sense of moral rectitude should

stand in clear contrast to “the demoralizing influences which

¹⁹ a corruption-ridden political life so strikingly manifests.” The Guardian called for “an abiding sense of undeviating justice”

in a “strangely disordered world” and quoted extensively from

²⁰ 112

²¹ FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONthe Writings of Bahá’u’lláh and ‘Abdu’l-Bahá, setting the sights

of the friends on the highest standards of honesty and trustwor -

²² thiness. He appealed to the believers to exemplify rectitude of conduct in every aspect of their lives—in their business dealings,

in their domestic lives, in all manner of employment, in every

²³ service they render to the Cause and to their people—and to observe its requirements in their uncompromising adherence

to the laws and principles of the Faith. That political life

²⁴ everywhere has continued to deteriorate at an alarming rate in the intervening years, as the very conception of statesmanship

has been drained of meaning, as policies have come to serve

the economic interests of the few in the name of progress, as

hypocrisy has been allowed to undermine the operation of

25 social and economic structures, is evident. If indeed great effort was required for the friends to uphold the high standards of the

Faith then, how much greater must be the exertion in a world

26 that rewards dishonesty, that encourages corruption, and that treats truth as a negotiable commodity. Profound is the confu-

sion that threatens the foundations of society, and unwavering

must be the resolve of all those involved in Bahá'í activity, lest

the slightest trace of self-interest becloud their judgment. Let

27 the coordinators of every training institute, the members of every Area Teaching Committee, every Auxiliary Board member

and every one of his or her assistants, and all members of every

local, regional and national Bahá'í body, whether elected or

appointed, appreciate the significance of the Guardian's plea to

28 ponder in their hearts the implications of the moral rectitude which he described with such clarity. May their actions serve

as a reminder to a beleaguered and weary humanity of its high

29 destiny and its inherent nobility.

16.33 No less pertinent to the success of the Bahá'í enterprise to-

day are the Guardian's forthright comments on the importance

17 of a chaste and holy life, "with its implications of modesty,

purity, temperance, decency, and clean-mindedness." He was

unequivocal in his language, summoning the friends to a life

18 unsullied "by the indecencies, the vices, the false standards, which an inherently deficient moral code tolerates, perpetuates,

and fosters." We need not provide for you here evidence of the

19 influence that such a deficient code now exerts on humanity as a whole; even the remotest spots on the globe are captivated by

its enticements. Yet we feel compelled to mention a few points

related specifically to the theme of purity. The forces at work

20 113

21 directed his appeal most fervently, are pernicious indeed.

Exhortations to remain pure and chaste will only succeed to

a limited degree in helping them to resist these forces. What

needs to be appreciated in this respect is the extent to which

²² young minds are affected by the choices parents make for their own lives, when, no matter how unintentionally, no matter how

innocently, such choices condone the passions of the world—its

²³ admiration for power, its adoration of status, its love of luxuries, its attachment to frivolous pursuits, its glorification of violence,

and its obsession with self-gratification. It must be realized that

the isolation and despair from which so many suffer are prod-

²⁴ ucts of an environment ruled by an all-pervasive materialism.

²⁵ And in this the friends must understand the ramifications of Bahá'u'lláh's statement that "the present-day order" must "be

rolled up, and a new one spread out in its stead." Throughout

²⁶ the world today, young people are among the most enthusiastic supporters of the Plan and the most ardent champions of the

Cause; their numbers will, we are certain, increase from year

to year. May every one of them come to know the bounties of a

life adorned with purity and learn to draw on the powers that

²⁷ flow through pure channels.

^{16.34} The Guardian next addressed the subject of prejudice,

stating patently that "any division or cleavage" in the ranks of

the Faith "is alien to its very purpose, principles, and ideals." He

made clear that the friends should manifest "complete freedom

from prejudice in their dealings with peoples of a different

¹⁷ race, class, creed, or color." He went on to discuss at length the specific question of racial prejudice, "the corrosion of which,"

he indicated, had "bitten into the fibre, and attacked the whole

¹⁸ social structure of American society" and which, he asserted at the time, "should be regarded as constituting the most vital

and challenging issue confronting the Bahá'í community at the

present stage of its evolution.” Independent of the strengths

19 and weaknesses of the measures taken by the American nation,

20 and the Bahá'í community evolving within it, in addressing this particular challenge,
the fact remains that prejudices of

all kinds—of race, of class, of ethnicity, of gender, of religious

21 belief—continue to hold a strong grip on humanity. While it is true that, at the level
of public discourse, great strides have been

22 taken in refuting the falsehoods that give rise to prejudice in whatever form, it still
permeates the structures of society and

23 114

24 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION is systematically impressed on the individual
consciousness. It

should be apparent to all that the process set in motion by the

current series of global Plans seeks, in the approaches it takes

and the methods it employs, to build capacity in every human

group, with no regard for class or religious background, with

25 no concern for ethnicity or race, irrespective of gender or social status, to arise and
contribute to the advancement of civiliza-

tion. We pray that, as it steadily unfolds, its potential to disable

26 every instrument devised by humanity over the long period of its childhood for one
group to oppress another may be realized.

16.35 The educational process associated with the training insti-

tute is, of course, helping to foster the spiritual conditions to

17 which the Guardian referred in The Advent of Divine Justice,

18 along with the many others mentioned in the writings that must distinguish the life
of the Bahá'í community—the spirit of unity

19 that must animate the friends, the ties of love that must bind them, the firmness in the
Covenant that must sustain them, and

the reliance and trust they must place on the power of divine

20 assistance, to note but a few. That such essential attributes are developed in the
context of building capacity for service, in an

environment that cultivates systematic action, is particularly

noteworthy. In promoting this environment, the Auxiliary

Board members and their assistants need to recognize the im-

21 portance of two fundamental, interlocking precepts: On the one hand, the high standard of conduct inculcated by Bahá'u'lláh's

Revelation can admit no compromise; it can, in no wise, be

22 lowered, and all must fix their gaze on its lofty heights. On the other, it must be acknowledged that, as human beings, we are

far from perfect; what is expected of everyone is sincere daily

23 effort. Self-righteousness is to be eschewed.

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16.36 Apart from the spiritual requisites of a sanctified Bahá'í life,

there are habits of thought that affect the unfoldment of the

global Plan, and their development has to be encouraged at the

level of culture. There are tendencies, as well, that need to be

gradually overcome. Many of these tendencies are reinforced by

17 approaches prevalent in society at large, which, not altogether unreasonably, enter into Bahá'í activity. The magnitude of the

challenge facing the friends in this respect is not lost on us. They

18 are called upon to become increasingly involved in the life of society, benefiting from its educational programs, excelling in

19 115

20 applying themselves to the advancement of its arts and sciences.

At the same time, they are never to lose sight of the aim of

the Faith to effect a transformation of society, remolding its

institutions and processes, on a scale never before witnessed. To

21 this end, they must remain acutely aware of the inadequacies of current modes of thinking and doing—this, without feeling the

least degree of superiority, without assuming an air of secrecy

22 or aloofness, and without adopting an unnecessarily critical stance towards society. There are a few specific points we wish

23 to mention in this connection.

16.37 It is heartening to note that the friends are approaching the

17 ated as they strive to put into practice the guidance received, and to learn from
experience, is impressive. We cannot help

18 noticing, however, that achievements tend to be more enduring in those regions
where the friends strive to understand the

totality of the vision conveyed in the messages, while difficulties

19 often arise when phrases and sentences are taken out of context and viewed as
isolated fragments. The institutions and agencies

20 of the Faith should help the believers to analyze but not reduce,

to ponder meaning but not dwell on words, to identify distinct

areas of action but not compartmentalize. We realize that this

21 is no small task. Society speaks more and more in slogans. We hope that the habits
the friends are forming in study circles to

work with full and complex thoughts and to achieve under -

22 standing will be extended to various spheres of activity.

16.38 Closely related to the habit of reducing an entire theme

17 into one or two appealing phrases is the tendency to perceive dichotomies, where, in
fact, there are none. It is essential

that ideas forming part of a cohesive whole not be held in

18 opposition to one another. In a letter written on his behalf,

19 Shoghi Effendi warned: "We must take the teachings as a great, balanced whole, not
seek out and oppose to each other two

strong statements that have different meanings; somewhere in

20 between, there are links uniting the two." How encouraged we have been to note that
many of the misunderstandings of the

past have fallen away as appreciation for the provisions of the

Plan has grown. Expansion and consolidation, individual action

and collective campaigns, refinement of the inner character and

consecration to selfless service—the harmonious relationship

21 116

22 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONbetween these facets of Bahá'í life is now readily
acknowledged.

It brings us equal pleasure to know that the friends are on their

guard, lest new false dichotomies be allowed to pervade their

thinking. They are well aware that the diverse elements of a

program of growth are complementary. The tendency to see

23 activities, and the agencies that support them, in competition with one another, a
tendency so common in society at large, is

24 being avoided by the community.

16.39 Finally, a significant advance in culture, one which we

17 have followed with particular interest, is marked by the rise in capacity to think in
terms of process. That, from the outset,

the believers have been asked to be ever conscious of the broad

processes that define their work is apparent from a careful

18 reading of even the earliest communications of the Guardian related to the first
national plans of the Faith. However, in a

world focused increasingly on the promotion of events, or at

19 best projects, with a mindset that derives satisfaction from the sense of expectation
and excitement they generate, maintaining

the level of dedication required for long-term action demands

considerable effort. The expansion and consolidation of the

Bahá'í community encompasses a number of interacting

20 processes, each of which contributes its share to the movement of humanity towards
Bahá'u'lláh's vision of a new World

Order. The lines of action associated with any given process

21 provide for the organization of occasional events, and from time to time, activities
take the shape of a project with a clear

beginning and a definite end. If, however, events are imposed on

the natural unfoldment of a process, they will disrupt its sound

evolution. If the projects undertaken in a cluster are not made

22 subordinate to the explicit needs of the processes unfolding there, they will yield little
fruit.

16.40 To understand the nature of the interacting processes that,

in their totality, engender the expansion and consolidation of

the Faith is vital to the successful execution of the Plan. In your

efforts to further such understanding, you and your auxiliaries

are encouraged to bear in mind a concept that lies at the foun-

¹⁷ dation of the current global enterprise and, indeed, at the very heart of every stage of the Divine Plan, namely, that progress

is achieved through the development of three participants—the

¹⁸ individual, the institutions, and the community. Throughout human history, interactions among these three have been

fraught with difficulties at every turn, with the individual

¹⁹ 117

and the community claiming precedence. Every society has

defined, in one way or another, the relationships that bind

the three, giving rise to periods of stability, interwoven with

turmoil. Today, in this age of transition, as humanity struggles

²⁰ to attain its collective maturity, such relationships—nay, the very conception of the individual, of social institutions, and

of the community—continue to be assailed by crises too

²¹ numerous to count. The worldwide crisis of authority provides proof enough. So grievous have been its abuses, and so deep

the suspicion and resentment it now arouses, that the world is

becoming increasingly ungovernable—a situation made all the

²² more perilous by the weakening of community ties.

^{16.41} Every follower of Bahá'u'lláh knows well that the purpose

¹⁷ of His Revelation is to bring into being a new creation. No soon-er had “the First Call gone forth from His lips than the whole

creation was revolutionized, and all that are in the heavens and

¹⁸ all that are on earth were stirred to the depths.” The individual,

¹⁹ the institutions, and the community—the three protagonists in the Divine Plan—are being shaped under the direct influence of

His Revelation, and a new conception of each, appropriate for

²⁰ a humanity that has come of age, is emerging. The relationships that bind them, too, are undergoing a profound transformation,

bringing into the realm of existence civilization-building powers

21 which can only be released through conformity with His decree.

At a fundamental level these relationships are characterized by

cooperation and reciprocity, manifestations of the interconnect -

22 edness that governs the universe. So it is that the individual,

with no regard for “personal benefits and selfish advantages,”

23 comes to see him- or herself as “one of the servants of God, the All-Possessing,”
whose only desire is to carry out His laws. So it

24 is that the friends come to recognize that “wealth of sentiment,

abundance of goodwill and effort” are of little avail when their

flow is not directed along proper channels, that “the unfettered

25 freedom of the individual should be tempered with mutual consultation and
sacrifice,” and that “the spirit of initiative and

enterprise should be reinforced by a deeper realization of the

supreme necessity for concerted action and a fuller devotion to

the common weal.” And so it is that all come to discern with

ease those areas of activity in which the individual can best

26 exercise initiative and those which fall to the institutions alone.

“With heart and soul,” the friends follow the directives of their

27 118

28 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION institutions, so that, as ‘Abdu’l-Bahá explains, “things
may be

properly ordered and well arranged.” This, of course, is not a

blind obedience; it is an obedience that marks the emergence of

a mature human race which grasps the implications of a system

29 as far-reaching as Bahá’u’lláh’s new World Order.

16.42 And those who are called upon from among the ranks of

such enkindled souls to serve on the institutions of that mighty

system understand well the Guardian’s words that “their func-

tion is not to dictate, but to consult, and consult not only among

themselves, but as much as possible with the friends whom they

represent.” “Never” would they be “led to suppose that they are

17 the central ornaments of the body of the Cause, intrinsically superior to others in capacity or merit, and sole promoters of

its teachings and principles.” “With extreme humility,” they

18 approach their tasks and “endeavor, by their open-mindedness,

19 their high sense of justice and duty, their candor, their modesty,

20 their entire devotion to the welfare and interests of the friends, the Cause, and humanity, to win, not only the confidence and

the genuine support and respect of those whom they serve, but

21 also their esteem and real affection.” Within the environment thus created, institutions invested with authority see themselves

as instruments for nurturing human potential, ensuring its

22 unfoldment along avenues productive and meritorious.

16.43 Composed of such individuals and such institutions, the

community of the Greatest Name becomes that spiritually

17 charged arena in which powers are multiplied in unified action.

It is of this community that ‘Abdu’l-Bahá writes: “When any

souls grow to be true believers, they will attain a spiritual

18 relationship with one another, and show forth a tenderness which is not of this world. They will, all of them, become

19 elated from a draught of divine love, and that union of theirs,

20 that connection, will also abide forever. Souls, that is, who will consign their own selves to oblivion, strip from themselves the

defects of humankind, and unchain themselves from human

bondage, will beyond any doubt be illumined with the heavenly

splendors of oneness, and will all attain unto real union in the

world that dieth not.”

16.44 As more and more receptive souls embrace the Cause of

God and throw in their lot with those already participating in

the global enterprise under way, the development and activity

**of the individual, the institutions, and the community are sure
to receive a mighty thrust forward. May a bewildered humanity**

¹⁷ 119

**onists by the followers of Bahá'u'lláh a pattern of collective life
that will propel it towards its high destiny. This is our ardent**
¹⁸ prayer in the Holy Shrines.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]